

# I4 Melchizedek

*The mysterious king of Salem and priest of the most high God, who blessed Abraham and pointed ahead to Christ.*

Melchizedek appears in only three verses of Genesis, and then he is gone. After Abram rescued Lot, this king of Salem, "the priest of the most high God," came out with bread and wine. He blessed Abram, praised God for the victory, and received a tenth of everything. Genesis gives him no parents, birth or death. Centuries later a psalm of David promises "a priest for ever after the order of Melchizedek," and Hebrews builds a whole chapter on him to explain how Jesus is our great High Priest. Few people say so little and are remembered so long.

## At a glance

|               |                                                                                                 |
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| Name          | Hebrew <i>Malki-tsedeq</i> , "king of righteousness" (Hebrews 7:2)                              |
| Title         | King of Salem, "which is, King of peace" (Hebrews 7:2)                                          |
| Office        | "The priest of the most high God" (Genesis 14:18)                                               |
| Family        | Not recorded. Hebrews calls him "without father, without mother, without descent" (Hebrews 7:3) |
| Key place     | Salem, probably Jerusalem (Psalm 76:2); the king's dale (Genesis 14:17)                         |
| Key people    | Abraham, the king of Sodom                                                                      |
| Main passages | Genesis 14:17–24; Psalm 110:4; Hebrews 5:6–10; 6:20–7:28                                        |
| New Testament | Hebrews 5–7, where the KJV spells his name "Melchisedec"                                        |

*"And Melchizedek king of Salem brought forth bread and wine:  
and he was the priest of the most high God."*

Genesis 14:18, KJV

# The life of Melchizedek

Genesis records one meeting and gives no dates or ages. It took place after Abram entered Canaan at 75 and before Ishmael was born when Abram was 86 (Genesis 12:4; 16:16).

- After the battle
- Comes out to meet Abram
- Abram returns from defeating Chedorlaomer and the kings with him. At the valley of Shaveh, the king's dale, the king of Sodom meets him, and Melchizedek brings out bread and wine. *Genesis 14:17-18*
- The same day
- Blesses Abram
- He says, "Blessed be Abram of the most high God, possessor of heaven and earth." Then he blesses God, who delivered Abram's enemies into his hand. *Genesis 14:19-20*
- The same day
- Receives a tenth
- Abram gives him "tithes of all." Then Abram refuses the king of Sodom's offer, swearing by "the LORD, the most high God." *Genesis 14:20-24*
- In a psalm of David
- A priest for ever
- God swears to David's Lord, "Thou art a priest for ever after the order of Melchizedek." *Psalms 110:1-4*
- In Hebrews
- A pattern of Christ
- Hebrews quotes Psalm 110 and explains that Jesus is a high priest of Melchizedek's kind, not of Aaron's. *Hebrews 5:6-10; 6:20-7:28*

## Group notes

# Key activities

Christians hold different views of who Melchizedek was. Many see him as a real Canaanite king-priest whose missing family record Hebrews uses as a picture of Christ. Some believe he was an appearance of the Son of God before the incarnation. Hebrews says he was "made like unto the Son of God" (Hebrews 7:3).

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- 1 **Brought bread and wine.** He met the weary victors with food and drink. *Genesis 14:18*
  - 2 **Served the most high God.** He was a priest of the true God outside Abram's family, before Israel or the law existed. *Genesis 14:18*
  - 3 **Blessed Abram.** He spoke a blessing over the man who carried God's promises. Hebrews notes that "the less is blessed of the better." *Genesis 14:19; Hebrews 7:6-7*
  - 4 **Gave God the credit.** He praised God, not Abram, for delivering Abram's enemies. *Genesis 14:20*
  - 5 **Received the tithe.** Abram gave him a tenth of all, and Hebrews says Levi in a sense paid tithes through Abraham. *Genesis 14:20; Hebrews 7:4-10*
  - 6 **Became a pattern.** His priesthood, not based on family line, became the model for a priest who lives for ever. *Psalms 110:4; Hebrews 7:15-17*
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## Group notes

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# Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Melchizedek.

## Old Testament

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|------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| Genesis 14:17–24 | The only account of his life                                |
| Psalms 110:4     | "Thou art a priest for ever after the order of Melchizedek" |

## New Testament

|                        |                                                                      |
|------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Hebrews 5:5–10         | Christ "called of God an high priest after the order of Melchisedec" |
| Hebrews 6:19–20        | Jesus our forerunner, within the veil, a priest for ever             |
| Hebrews 7:1–10         | His blessing and tithe show him greater than Abraham                 |
| Hebrews 7:11–28        | A priest "after the power of an endless life"                        |
| Echo: Matthew 22:41–45 | Jesus applies Psalm 110 to himself                                   |
| Echo: Matthew 26:26–29 | Bread and wine, though not linked to Melchizedek                     |

### For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Melchizedek bring and say when he met Abram (Genesis 14:18–20)?
2. *Understand:* Why does Hebrews make so much of the fact that Genesis gives Melchizedek no family line?
3. *Apply:* Melchizedek gave God the credit for Abram's victory. What recent success should you thank God for?
4. *Apply:* Jesus "ever liveth to make intercession" (Hebrews 7:25). How could that truth change the way you pray this week?